# Roam Alone

*Game Design Document*

Working title • Version 0.2 • 27 October 2026

## Purpose and immediate direction

Build a small, convincing psychological horror experience about the vulnerability of traveling alone in a camper van. Beautiful daytime exploration establishes freedom and comfort; nighttime disturbances turn that same familiar space into a place the player must actively protect.

The immediate production goal is one van, one campsite, one playable night and one compelling horror event. This document turns that goal into a testable prototype plan while keeping later episodes conditional on what the first night proves.

## Project context

Project location: D:\unrealProjects\RoamAlone
Engine target: Unreal Engine 5.8.4, as supplied by the developer
Development model: solo developer using C++, Blueprints, Rider, Codex and Unreal MCP

## How to read this document

CONFIRMED identifies concepts explicitly supplied in the current brief. PROPOSED identifies recommendations introduced here for review or prototyping. OPEN identifies decisions that remain unresolved. A proposal is not an approved production commitment.

The referenced chat was consulted. Its accessible history contains setup discussion and unresolved content references rather than the earlier design details. The current request is therefore the authority for the design baseline. The project files and installed tool versions were not audited for this document.

## Document map


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Recommended next action: graybox the exterior route, van threshold and interior, then prove movement and door locking before producing polished assets.

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# Vision and scope

## Experience vision

CONFIRMED — The player is a female solo van-life vlogger traveling among campsites in the United States. The game combines scenic days with increasingly threatening nights. Isolation, uncertain intent and the fragile privacy of a camper support the psychological horror premise.

## Design pillars

- Freedom becomes vulnerability. Let the player enjoy the view and learn the campsite before darkness makes distance, sightlines and exposure matter.
- The van is an active refuge. Free interior movement, a visible body, contextual interactions and manual locks make safety feel physical and deliberate.
- Fear comes from readable uncertainty. Footsteps, knocks, vehicles and possible intruders should provoke decisions without revealing every cause.
- Small spaces carry authored tension. Reuse a well-understood van and build distinct campsite episodes instead of expanding into an open world.

PROPOSED evaluation rule — Every prototype feature must improve orientation, vulnerability, agency or recovery. If it does none of these, defer it.

## Scope boundaries

| Area | Confirmed direction | Prototype boundary proposed |
|---|---|---|
| World | Episodic campsites and nights | One compact campsite with a short outdoor route |
| Travel | Brief cinematic simulates travel | A transition or simple arrival shot; no vehicle physics |
| Character | Female protagonist; Quinn placeholder | Quinn proves mechanics; final character and animation deferred |
| Threat | Disturbances and possible intrusion | One authored event; no general enemy simulation |
| Needs | Occasional reasons to risk going outside | One water or bathroom task; no survival meters |
| Weather | Ultra Dynamic Sky and Weather direction | One controlled day to night preset after compatibility check |

## Decisions deliberately left open

Final title, release platforms, total episode count, game length, combat, death rules, threat identity and whether events have supernatural causes are unresolved. No multiplayer, crafting, hunger economy, procedural world or extensive driving is required for the prototype.

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# Core loop and player control

## The episode loop

CONFIRMED structure — Arrive at a campsite, experience its scenic daytime identity, prepare the camper, endure escalating nighttime disturbances, then transition onward through a short travel cinematic.

PROPOSED playable loop — Explore → learn the route and exits → complete a modest routine → close and manually lock doors → notice a disturbance → choose how to investigate or wait → face an unavoidable outdoor task → return and reassess safety → reach the morning resolution.

The player should make spatial and timing decisions, not manage a large inventory. Vlogging establishes motivation and mood; it need not become a separate scoring or editing system.

## Perspective and movement

CONFIRMED — Outdoor play uses third person. The camper interior uses immersive first person with a visible body, free movement and contextual interaction. The player is not anchored to a seat or a fixed camera inside.

PROPOSED — Use a threshold volume with a short camera blend and transition hysteresis to avoid rapid toggling at the doorway. Preserve facing and input continuity. Block neither the doorway nor the player's view during the blend. Interior body visibility may use selective mesh hiding near the camera while retaining legs and torso where practical.

## Provisional input map

| Action | Keyboard and mouse proposal | Behavior |
|---|---|---|
| Move and look | WASD and mouse | Same movement intention across both perspectives |
| Interact | E | Context action such as opening a door or using a tap |
| Lock or unlock | R near a door lock | Explicit separate action with a visible state response |
| Light | F | Toggle a handheld light if included in the MVP |
| Move faster | Shift | Optional; speed and stamina rules remain open |
| Pause | Esc | Settings, restart checkpoint and quit |

OPEN — Controller mappings, crouch, sprint, camera shoulder, object inspection and whether the player can change view manually. Keep these out of the first build unless a playtest demonstrates a need.

## Interaction contract proposed

A prompt states the action and target. A locked handle produces a clear response. A close command does not silently lock the door. Only show interactions in range and unobstructed; prioritize the lock when the player aims at the lock itself.

*04 DESIGN AND PRODUCTION*

# Gameplay systems

## Doors and the camper boundary

CONFIRMED — Doors can be locked manually. PROPOSED model — Track open or closed and locked or unlocked as independent state, with locking valid only when fully closed. An open door must first close before locking. Repeated inputs cannot reverse an animation into an invalid state.

Represent the handle, lock, animation and sound as views of the same authoritative state. A failed open attempt on a locked door plays restrained feedback and changes nothing. Prototype intrusion occurs through an unlocked door or an authored external disturbance; any forced breach rule requires a separate design decision.

## Needs as occasional story tasks

CONFIRMED — Bathroom or water needs occasionally create risk outside. PROPOSED — Implement one authored task, triggered after an initial disturbance. A simple objective explains the destination; completion changes a task flag. Avoid continuous thirst, bodily urgency timers, resource crafting and repeated chores.

Let the player hesitate long enough to listen and plan. If waiting must eventually advance the sequence, define a clear fallback beat. Do not punish an accessibility setting or slower navigation with an invisible deadline.

## Disturbance and event system proposed

| System | Minimum behavior | Deferral |
|---|---|---|
| Sound cues | Place and trigger footsteps, knocks and a vehicle cue | Acoustic simulation of every actor |
| Event sequence | Advance on prerequisite flags and completed beats | General purpose procedural horror director |
| Threat representation | Offscreen source or short controlled silhouette | Patrol, search and combat AI |
| Objective state | One current objective and task completion flags | Quest tree or branching journal |
| Checkpoint | Restore one safe state and event flags | Save anywhere and cross episode persistence |

## Failure and recovery

OPEN — Whether the game includes death, capture, a chase or only narrative consequences. PROPOSED prototype default — An unlocked-door mistake causes a brief encounter and checkpoint restart, without combat or a full chase. If this distracts from the core event, begin with a nonlethal escalation and evaluate failure later.

Acceptance focus: the player understands what changed and can retry without replaying a long opening. Reloading restores doors, lighting, objective and event progression together.

*05 DESIGN AND PRODUCTION*

# Horror pacing and the first night

PROPOSED sequence — The following is an implementable test scene, not established story canon. Use authored triggers and delays to make the event repeatable during development. Timing ranges are tuning suggestions, not a committed episode length.

| Beat | Player experience | Trigger and implementation |
|---|---|---|
| Daylight arrival | A scenic clearing feels inviting | Player learns the van, water point and short return route |
| Preparation | The camper becomes familiar | Player practices closing and locking the main door |
| First anomaly | Footsteps stop close to the van | Begin after interior entry; play one spatial sound sequence |
| Silence | The player waits and checks the boundary | Leave a quiet window; avoid immediately stacking a sting |
| Required outing | Water must be collected outside | Enable the water objective after the first disturbance |
| Exposure | A distant vehicle light crosses the trees | Trigger once on the route; keep the return path legible |
| Compelling event | A knock comes from the side just checked | After return, play three localized knocks; handle moves if locked |
| Consequence | The player tests the safety they established | Locked: threat withdraws. Unlocked: brief encounter or recovery beat |
| Morning | The familiar campsite looks changed | Resolve the episode with one subtle trace and a quiet exit |

## Why this event is worth testing

It links anticipation, a vulnerable outdoor trip and manual locks. The same van changes meaning without needing a large enemy system. The lock state affects the result, so preparation has a visible consequence. The identity and explanation of the visitor remain open.

## Pacing rules proposed

- Establish at least one ordinary example of a sound or object before making it suspicious. Keep most time quiet enough for the player to notice change.
- Escalate from distant presence to proximity to boundary testing. Avoid repeated full-volume surprises that make every cue feel equivalent.
- Never spawn the threat in an obviously observed empty space. Gate a silhouette on player sightline, or keep the event offscreen.
- After a major beat, allow a recovery interval. Use a development reset button and event log so timing changes remain easy to test.

*06 DESIGN AND PRODUCTION*

# Narrative and campsite design

## Narrative foundation

CONFIRMED — The protagonist is a woman documenting solo van life. Travel supplies episodic structure; daytime beauty and nighttime danger create the central emotional contrast. Her name, age, background, audience, route and reasons for traveling remain OPEN.

PROPOSED — Use short vlog introductions and private reactions to contrast the trip she presents publicly with the fear she experiences alone. Keep essential objectives understandable without watching a video. Environmental changes and restrained dialogue should carry more of the prototype than exposition.

OPEN — Whether a single pursuer links campsites, each episode has a distinct threat, or the player cannot reliably separate human danger from psychological interpretation. Test the first night without resolving the larger mystery or committing to an ending.

## Vlog cutscenes

CONFIRMED possibility — AI-generated vlog footage may be used. PROPOSED — Test a short nonessential clip only after the core loop works. Use a placeholder image, text card or in-engine shot first. Evaluate continuity of face, voice, clothing and van, plus usage rights and revision effort. An AI video pipeline is not required to validate gameplay.

## One campsite graybox

PROPOSED layout — Place the van in a clearing, a water point or bathroom along one readable path, a road beyond partial tree cover and two controlled offscreen sound positions. Keep the playable boundary modest and justified by terrain. An approximately 30–60 second walk to the task is a tuning starting point, not a fixed distance.

- Day route: reveal the destination and a recognizable return landmark before night. Avoid navigation difficulty masquerading as fear.
- Van interior: fit a usable aisle, sleeping area and the interactable door. Test body collision and camera clearance before adding clutter.
- Night route: shape a few sightlines and one exposed segment. Preserve a readable van silhouette or landmark without lighting the entire scene.
- Event staging: reserve a hidden approach or sound anchor near the van; keep the outdoor task accessible regardless of door state.

## Episode expansion rule proposed

A later campsite should change one spatial pressure and one horror idea while reusing the van and foundational systems. Do not build the next episode until the first can be completed, understood and reset reliably.

*07 DESIGN AND PRODUCTION*

# Art audio and atmosphere

## Visual direction

CONFIRMED — Scenic days should be beautiful; nights should become increasingly threatening. Ultra Dynamic Sky and Weather are the chosen atmosphere tools. Quinn is the confirmed female prototype character. Final character design and asset style remain OPEN.

PROPOSED — Use a grounded contemporary van and campsite with restrained environmental detail. Build a believable personal refuge through a few meaningful objects rather than dense clutter. Daylight should establish the same landmarks that become ambiguous at night.

## Lighting and weather plan proposed

- Begin with one clear daytime state, one dusk transition and one night state. Lock time and weather at key horror beats so their readability is repeatable.
- Create a temporary lighting fallback before plugin integration. Verify the installed sky and weather versions against the actual project before depending on their APIs or packaging behavior.
- Keep the interior readable through practical lamps and reflected light. Tune exposure so looking out of the van does not erase necessary cues or make the interior unusable.
- Rain and wind can mask sounds in later tests, but add no weather-dependent puzzle or systemic forecast to the MVP.

## Sound hierarchy

| Layer | Purpose | Prototype asset budget proposed |
|---|---|---|
| Day ambience | Sell a pleasant place and normal activity | One loop plus a few distinct local sounds |
| Night ambience | Leave room for threat cues | One quieter loop with controllable wind |
| Van feedback | Confirm interaction and safety state | Door open, close, lock, unlock and handle rattle |
| Threat cues | Communicate direction and proximity | Footsteps, knocks and one distant vehicle cue |
| Music | Shape key transitions sparingly | Optional short texture; no continuous score needed |

## Production priorities

Spend polish first on the door interaction, sound placement, night visibility and the van threshold. A small coherent set of placeholders is sufficient elsewhere. Record asset sources and licenses as assets enter the project. Final voice acting, a detailed protagonist and bespoke cinematics are later production choices.

PROPOSED audio rule — A critical cue must remain understandable at comfortable volume. Build tension with timing and location, not painful loudness.

*08 DESIGN AND PRODUCTION*

# User experience and accessibility

## Interface direction proposed

Keep play readable with a small contextual prompt and a brief current objective. Show lock feedback at the door through animation, sound and concise text. Do not display an omniscient threat indicator that resolves the mystery. A short objective reminder should help a player who returns after a break.

Use a pause menu with resume, settings, restart checkpoint and quit. On restart, clearly identify the checkpoint. The opening tutorial should cover movement, the perspective transition and one close then lock sequence inside normal play.

## Prototype accessibility baseline proposed

| Need | Implementation target | Verification |
|---|---|---|
| Motion comfort | Separate look sensitivity; camera shake off; reduced head motion; configurable blend | Walk through the threshold repeatedly without forced sway |
| Readable interaction | Scalable text, high contrast prompts and generous target range | Read prompts against both daylight and dark interior |
| Hearing access | Captions for speech and meaningful sounds; optional directional labels | Complete the event with sound muted |
| Input access | Rebind actions; avoid rapid tapping and long mandatory holds | Complete close, lock and water task using alternate bindings |
| Volume control | Separate master, ambience, effects and dialogue controls | Critical cues remain usable with reduced volume |
| Pacing access | Pause during active play; avoid hidden urgency on the outdoor task | Pause and resume at each event stage |

## Preserving uncertainty accessibly

Caption what is perceptible, such as “Footsteps outside, left,” rather than naming a stalker or giving an exact location. If a directional caption would reveal more than the sound, broaden it. Communicate an important visual-only cue through an equivalent sound or caption.

## Comfort and failure

PROPOSED — Offer a concise content notice for stalking, intrusion and sudden scares, updated when content is finalized. Make cutscenes skippable with essential information restated in play. Keep any first-person field of view and body animation comfortable in the small interior.

OPEN — Final controller support, difficulty settings, reduced scare mode, localization languages and subtitle speaker identification. Target hardware and release platforms must be chosen before setting performance and certification requirements.

*09 DESIGN AND PRODUCTION*

# Technical architecture and workflow

CONFIRMED — Use C++ for foundational systems and Blueprints for iteration, with Rider, Codex and Unreal MCP in the workflow. The names below are proposed responsibilities, not claims about classes already present in the project.

| Foundation proposed in C++ | Iteration proposed in Blueprints or data |
|---|---|
| Player locomotion and perspective state | Camera blend tuning, animation selection and threshold placement |
| Interaction interface and target selection | Prompts, object responses, interaction sounds and effects |
| Door component with validated state changes | Van meshes, hinge animation and handle presentation |
| Night sequence state and one-shot event tracking | Event order, delays, cue positions and conditional branches |
| Objective flags and checkpoint snapshot | Objective wording, task presentation and checkpoint location |
| Settings and input action handling | UI presentation and comfort defaults |

## State and event flow proposed

Player requests interaction → target validates range and state → door or task state changes → sequence receives a completion signal → the next eligible beat starts. Presentation reacts to committed state. Avoid letting a sound, animation callback and UI prompt each maintain separate copies of lock state.

A compact episode definition can hold beat identifiers, prerequisites and tuning values. Start with a direct authored sequence if that is quicker; generalize only after the second sequence needs the same behavior. Multiplayer replication is outside the prototype.

## Persistence and debugging proposed

Store current beat, completed one-shot events, objective flags, door state and the selected lighting state at a single safe checkpoint. Cancel active timers and effects before restoring. Provide developer controls to jump to a beat, reset the night and display current state. Seed any timing variation for repeatable testing.

## Build and tool discipline

PROPOSED — Keep source control and a recoverable baseline before assisted edits. Use Codex for small reviewable changes and Unreal MCP for supported editor tasks after confirming the connected project. Verify results in the editor and a packaged build; do not treat a successful tool call as gameplay validation.

Engine 5.8.4 is the developer-supplied target. No engine release status, installed plugin compatibility or MCP setup is verified here. First milestone checks the actual project, C++ build, plugin loading and packaged launch. Avoid designing around unverified version-specific APIs.

*10 DESIGN AND PRODUCTION*

# MVP backlog and acceptance

PROPOSED MVP — One complete first-night experience. A rough 10–15 minute test session is an initial pacing hypothesis, not a promised game length. It can be shorter if the interaction and horror idea are already proven.

| Priority | Deliverable | Acceptance evidence |
|---|---|---|
| P0 | Walkable campsite and camper | Player reaches the task and returns; no collision trap |
| P0 | Third person outside and first person inside | Visible body; free interior movement; stable doorway transitions |
| P0 | Manual door locking | Closing does not auto-lock; locked open attempts fail clearly |
| P0 | One outdoor need | Task advances once and does not require survival meters |
| P0 | One horror event | Footsteps, outing and boundary test occur in the intended order |
| P0 | Completion and recovery | Night reaches morning; reset restores the intended safe state |
| P0 | Basic readable presentation | Critical sound captions, usable prompts and comfort controls |
| P1 | Atmosphere integration | Chosen sky and weather state works in a packaged build |
| Later | Vlog video and travel polish | Only after the playable loop passes review |

## Functional verification checklist

- Complete the locked and unlocked door branches. Attempt locking while open, repeated interaction, interruption and reload at the checkpoint.
- Cross the van threshold slowly, quickly and backward. Check camera clipping, visible body, collision, prompt focus and control continuity.
- Wait inside without progressing; revisit the task trigger; return early; pause during a cue. Verify no deadlock, duplicate event or missing objective.
- Run from packaged launch through morning and restart. Check atmosphere, captions, settings and missing assets outside the editor.

## Player test gate proposed

Observe a small first round of three fresh players. Ask what they believed the lock did, why they went outside and which moment made them feel unsafe. Proceed when players can finish without developer directions, understand their safety action and identify the intended event as a memorable threat. If navigation or prompts dominate their feedback, fix those before adding content.

Record completion, assistance needed, confusion and strongest fear moment. These are qualitative prototype signals; three players do not establish market demand or final accessibility coverage.

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# Milestones and production risks

PROPOSED plan — Advance by evidence, not calendar promises. Estimate dates after the first graybox and build check. Each milestone ends with a playable build and a short list of unresolved issues.

| Gate | Work package | Exit condition |
|---|---|---|
| M0 Baseline | Open project, compile, check tools and assets | Correct engine and plugin versions recorded; packaged test launches |
| M1 Embodiment | Graybox, perspectives, interaction and doors | Van entry and manual locking feel clear and reliable |
| M2 First night | Outdoor task, authored cues and event branches | Full sequence completes and resets without state errors |
| M3 Atmosphere | Night lighting, spatial sound, captions and comfort | Core scene readable and threatening at comfortable settings |
| M4 Validation | Fresh player observation and packaged regression | MVP acceptance met; retain, revise or cut decisions recorded |
| M5 Expansion decision | Estimate next campsite and production asset needs | Approve a second episode only if reusable foundation is stable |

## Risk register

| Risk | Mitigation and scope response |
|---|---|
| Interior camera and body clipping | Test aisle and threshold first; simplify animation before rebuilding the van |
| Horror feels scripted or unfair | Tie outcomes to readable actions; use silence and spatial cues; revise timing from observation |
| Feature growth overwhelms solo capacity | Keep one task and event; defer combat, driving and broad AI |
| Plugin or engine incompatibility | Verify early in a copy; retain a basic atmosphere fallback and known working build |
| Asset and AI media inconsistency | Use placeholders until validated; track licenses and continuity before production use |
| No target performance budget | Choose hardware before final assets; profile the packaged worst night scene |

## Cut order proposed

If the milestone slips, cut vlog footage, travel polish, extra props and weather variation first. Preserve movement, manual locks, the outdoor risk and one effective horror event. If those cannot coexist clearly, reduce the campsite and sequence before adding new systems.

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# Decision log and next actions

This is the initial decision record. CONFIRMED rows restate the current brief. PROPOSED and OPEN rows require developer judgment or prototype evidence before becoming production commitments. Update this log when a choice changes.

| ID | Status | Decision or question | Next evidence or action |
|---|---|---|---|
| D01 | Confirmed | Female solo van-life vlogger in US campsites | Keep as the experience foundation |
| D02 | Confirmed | Scenic days and escalating nights | Validate emotional contrast in one location |
| D03 | Confirmed | Third person outdoors; embodied first person inside | Prove camera and collision in the graybox |
| D04 | Confirmed | Manual locks and occasional outdoor needs | Build one door and one task first |
| D05 | Confirmed | Episodic sites; cinematic travel | Defer driving and open world systems |
| D06 | Confirmed | C++ foundation and Blueprint iteration | Record actual project and tool baseline at M0 |
| D07 | Proposed | Knocks after a water outing as the first event | Test whether players connect locking to outcome |
| D08 | Open | Death, capture, chase or nonlethal consequence | Choose the smallest readable recovery at M2 |
| D09 | Open | Threat identity and overarching story | Resolve after the first night establishes tone |
| D10 | Open | Platform, hardware, episode count and duration | Set before full production estimates |
| D11 | Open | Final character, vlog format and AI media use | Evaluate continuity, rights and production cost |
| D12 | Proposed | One checkpoint and no survival economy | Retain unless playtests identify a concrete need |

## First implementation session

- Verify the existing project opens and compiles; record actual versions and create a recoverable baseline.
- Graybox the camper, door threshold, short route and one outdoor destination using Quinn.
- Implement perspective transition and manual lock feedback, then test from both sides of the door.
- Create an event stub that plays one localized knock only after the player returns. Expand to the full night after movement and state are reliable.

Change record — Version 0.2 corrects the prototype character to Quinn, the female model, following developer clarification. Version 0.1 established the supplied design baseline and explicitly labeled prototype proposals. No release date, commercial scope or unresolved narrative choice is approved by this document.